



Lax refereeing, tough President

Grave concern: East Bengal's coach, Carles Cuadrat, was visibly vexed at the lax supervision and rued that his side was the victim of "inconsistent refereeing" in their draw with Odisha FC. PTI

A storm is brewing in the country's top domestic football leagues, with a **string of refereeing errors** prompting the AIFF president to step in and take action.

East Bengal head coach Carles Cuadrat could only despair at the glaring refereeing oversights when his team was denied two clear penalties against Odisha FC, which saw the match ending goalless and the Kolkata giant had to be satisfied with a point. Action replays showed that the Odisha defender Mourtada Fall had clearly handled the ball while trying to block East Bengal striker Javier Severio's shot. Minutes later Odisha's other defender, Jerry Lalrinzuala, brought down the East Bengal's attacker P. V. Vishnu by tugging the latter's jersey inside his own box. **It was a clear case of infringement that called for a penalty but referee S. Senthil Nathan failed to notice the foul and looked the other way.**

Cuadrat was visibly vexed at the lax supervision and rued that his side was the victim of "inconsistent refereeing". East Bengal's case was one among the

many instances of refereeing errors in the ongoing Indian Super League (ISL) that have been reported by the participating clubs. This prompted the All India Football Federation (AIFF) president, Kalyan Chaubey, to call for an urgent need for accountability on the part of the referee department. The AIFF president urged officials to take serious note of the continuous errors and mounting refereeing issues this season in India's top two leagues, the ISL and the I-League, during a 'Refereeing Review Meeting', held on New Year's eve.

The AIFF president, who is a former goalkeeper having represented a number of top flight clubs in the country, knew the bane of poor refereeing and "expressed concern over the mounting referee issues and deprivation of 'fair play' due to plain sight errors for participating clubs," said an AIFF report. The meeting, which lasted more than four hours,

found a total of 24 controversial 'Key Match Incidents' (KMI) from seven ISL and four I-League games. "Clubs have submitted hard evidence in the form of videos to back their claims. As officials and administrators, we have to work towards minimising these mistakes. We cannot hide behind the mask of the 'acceptable 15 per cent human error norm'. Most of these complaints are of plain sight errors falling under the 15 per cent norm, which hampers the clubs, players and leagues," Chaubey said.

AIFF had set up the Elite Development Referee Programme in January 2023 but it is yet to bear results. "Through the reviews of the videos we have a clear case of one club being at the receiving end of refereeing decisions that went against them twice in two games of the 10 played so far. In their argument, that's 20% of wrong decisions against them, ruining their prospects in the season